

School Committee - Committee of the Whole Notes - November 2, 2020

Subject of the Committee of the Whole: Kids Corner Program Offerings

Vice Chair Ruseau - started meeting at 4:56 PM - Mayor was having issue connecting

Member Van der Kloot - Roll Call - 7-0

Mayor - Kids Corner presentation by Asst. Superintendent Galusi

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - Sharing slidedeck - Welcome to Kids Corner - my children and Joan Bowen's children went through this program - daycare that is provided to MPS employees, infant to Pre K, exciting environment to learn & succeed - Hours 7:30 AM - 4 PM, M-F - follow school calendar - it is closed on school vacation weeks & summer - focus on social emotional development of the students - 2 outdoor play areas for students - classrooms are inviting spaces, making sure compliant with Covid guidelines - supplies & book bins had to be individualized - all protocols for reopening followed ECC guidelines and working with Toni Wray

Spreadsheet regarding other daycares in Medford - Hours of operation tend to be the same, Kids Corner Program - no other district offers this to their employees - Medford is unique - a bit of a discounted rate, so cost is slightly lower

Member Ruseau - analysis of what it costs to run the program? Do we operate at a loss here?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - \$ ½ M - but would have to double check that projection. But I don't know how we could rent out the space as they are classrooms

Member. Ruseau - tough budget coming up - look at the rates - if running at a loss, then we may have to re look at it - I'd like to at least break even

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - projection for \$1/2M - historically doesn't operate at a loss, but why this is the projection, I'd have to look at it more closely - \$116,000 - salaries - this program makes a positive impact on the community

Member Ruseau - maybe provide a separate column as to what this is actually costing the city? Rates should reflect so we can at least break even

Member. Van der Kloot - how many students during covid vs. regular time?

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - 2018-2019 - 58, 2019-2020 - 64, 2020 - 2021 - 3 in infant room and 9-10 in toddler room

Member Van der Kloot - have we advertised to the Medford community?

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - yes with help from the Medford Family Network

Member Graham - how much space in regular times? Is 64 the most students we could have?

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - there were 64 students last year, utilizing 4 classrooms - but would have to check with Linda and Dave for the ECC guidelines

Member Graham - why is only available to Medford employees? Maybe teachers who live here, but teach elsewhere might find this helpful. Do we have staffing challenges in this program, as we tend to do in the after school program? Would it be easier to hire other staff as needed?

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - I haven't heard staffing was an issue

Member Graham - What are the covid precautions?

Asst. Galusi -Changes were made to keep students/families safe. Families have to complete a checklist just like every other student who enters a school building - each of the students have their own supplies and students over 2 years of age and over must wear masks - In the past, food was able to be heated up by staff, but that can no longer happen

Ms. Wray - For warmed food needs - parents/caregivers must warm it in a thermos container.- people understood and had no complaints

Member Graham - what are we recommending for a reserve in the Kids Corner revolving account? Just understanding what those numbers are and what does the expense report look like? What are we paying for health insurance? If I was the Mayor, we should consider all of this at budget time

Mayor - city covers \$18M for the employer side of the city's health insurance for the schools

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - we need a clearer way of communicating for each account - What is the best practice? It's a challenge - are we trying to grow this program? If so, we are taking a risk. Do we have the infrastructure support that we might need? Our community has the right to easily access this information

Member Graham - \$287,000 - sitting in this account. Why is it there? Is it a rainy day fund for a pandemic?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - no that's definitely not what is happening

Member Mustone - I know the high number of 64 was from last year - with covid what is the full enrollment for this year?

Linda - 2 staff - 16 children -

Member Mustone - so preschool can have up to 20?

Linda - 2 - 20 now 2- 16 - and now have 7 - 3 in infant room and can have 9

Member Ruseau - We transfer funds for other line items that might be in the negative columns...

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - I definitely want to look at it more closely

Mayor - you can give it to us in writing

Member.Kreatz - Can you explain extending it to an older Kids Corner group - which could help with revenue

Asst. Superintendent Galusi - we are working on that now - the Sr Division as stated by DaveD. Murphy - it would be located a classroom above the younger kids, with socially distanced desks - to offer to our employees who have children in K-6

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - it would be like a learning center which other districts have begun to offer. It will provide mask breaks and students can get outside as well. It's a way to hopefully supplement our revenue and re deploy our extra staff as needed

Member Kreatz - how are the rates going to be determined?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - rates are 50% of preschool rate as we aren't offering a structured program - We hope our staff will take advantage of it

Member Kreatz - Is this only for MPS & municipal employees or open to the entire community?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - once we have a sense of the level of interest and figure our space availability, we may open to the entire community. Additionally, if we have the space/interest, the general public's cost would be different

Member Graham - when we talk about Kids Corner - Atty Greenspan said we should be setting the rates before next school year - to be in alignment with our budget responsibilities

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - we want to get this out, to get people enrolled so we can prepare for next year

Dave Ambrose - teacher at MHS since 2004 - I wanted to speak as I very much value this program. My kids went through this program. Kids Corner is a big reason that the teachers stay in Medford - quite a benefit for our teachers/staff - I would argue a nickel of a loss, is a big gain for our teachers to stay working here - It's quite a value to our community - there are a number of other parents on the call today who support this program - If rates will be changing, maybe a discussion could be had with the parents involved? Thank you for your time

Member Kreatz - Maybe a commercial can be made and played on MCM?

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - yes, we will look into that

Mayor - we will await update & proposal for next year

Asst. Superintendent Murphy - Kids Corner opened today. We hope that the learning center will open Thursday and seats are available.

Mayor - Thank you. Is there a motion to adjourn? Motion to adjourn by Member Kreatz, seconded by Member Van der Kloot

Roll Call - 7-0

Mayor - Committee of the Whole adjourned - 5:50 PM